**MICROSOFT INNOVATION CHALLENGE HACKATHON March 2026**
**OFFICIAL RULES**

## 1. SPONSOR

These Official Rules ("*Rules*") govern the operation of the Microsoft Innovation Challenge Hackathon March 2026 ("*Contest*"). Microsoft Corporation, One Microsoft Way, Redmond, WA, 98052, USA, is the Contest sponsor ("*Sponsor*").

## 2. DEFINITIONS

In these Rules, "*Microsoft,*" "*we,*" "*our,*" and "*us*" refer to Sponsor and "*you*" and "*yourself*" refers to a Contest participant, or the parent/legal guardian of any Contest entrant who has not reached the age of majority to contractually obligate themselves in their legal place of residence. By entering you (your parent/legal guardian if you are not the age of majority in your legal place of residence) agree to be bound by these Rules. "*Team*" and "*Teams*" refers to a group of up to five (5) Contest participants working together to produce a single entry. "*Program*" means the Innovation Challenge Program sponsored by Microsoft in connection with the following non-profit organizations (each a "*Organization*"): BITE-CON, Black Partner Growth Initiative, Black Women In Artificial Intelligence, Blacks in Technology Foundation, Código Facilito, DIO, GenSpark, i.c. Stars, Hawaii Annual Code Challenge (HACC), Joining Hands in Unison, Loudoun Freedom Center, Microsoft Software and Systems Academy (MSSA), Musa Labs, NASA Space Apps Chicago, NASA Space Apps Mountain View, Society of Hispanic Professional Engineers (SHPE), Propel2Excel, TechBridge, TekHub Labs, or Women in Cloud.

## 3. ENTRY PERIOD

The Contest starts at 12:00 a.m. Pacific Time (PT) on March 16, 2026 and ends at 11:30 p.m. PT on March 27, 2026 ("*Entry Period*").

## 4. ELIGIBILITY

This is a trade Contest is a closed promotion open only to Teams that meet the following criteria:

- **Team Members:** Each member of a Team ("*Team Member*") must: (a) be either currently employed or pursuing employment in the field of software research or software sales and development, (b) have participated in Program, and (c) have received an invitation to participate in the Contest, and (d) be eighteen (18) years of age or older to be eligible. If you are eighteen (18) years of age or older but have not reached the age of majority in your legal place of residence, then you must have consent of a parent/legal guardian.
- **Teams:** Each Team must be comprised of between two (2) and five (5) Team Members.

Each Team is fully responsible for (i) the conduct of their Team Members; and (ii) the consequences of any misconduct by their Team Members. By registering a Team for the Contest, you represent and warrant that you have obtained the written consent of each Team Member or, for any Team Member who has not reached the age of majority in their legal place of residence, their parent or guardian, to participate in the Contest.

Employees and directors of Microsoft Corporation and its subsidiaries, affiliates, advertising agencies, and Contest Parties are not eligible, nor are persons involved in the execution or administration of this promotion, or the family members of each above (parents, children, siblings, spouse/domestic partners,

or individuals residing in the same household). Void in Cuba, Iran, North Korea, Sudan, Syria, Region of Crimea, Russia, and where otherwise prohibited by law.

If you are participating in your capacity as an employee, it is your sole responsibility to comply with your employer's gift policies. Microsoft will not be party to any disputes or actions related to this matter. Microsoft is committed to complying with government gift and ethics rules and therefore **government and public sector employees are not eligible** to enter.

## 5. HOW TO ENTER

Upon completing the Program you will receive an email message from Microsoft, inviting you to participate in the Contest. Visit the Contest website ("*Innovation Studio*") at https://innovationstudio.microsoft.com/hackathons/Innovation-Challenge-Spring-2025

To create and submit an entry, your Team must:

5.1 Create a software solution ("*Solution*") that meets the following requirements:

(a) Leverages Microsoft Foundry orrelies at least one (1) of the Available Foundry Tools listed at https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/azure/ai-services/what-are-ai-services#available-azure-ai-services ("*Azure Tools*"); and

- For the avoidance of doubt, Azure Tools do not include Azure AI Services that are listed as "retired" or "scheduled for retirement".

(b) Solves for one (1) of the use cases, as described on Innovation Studio at https://innovationstudio.microsoft.com/hackathons/Innovation-Challenge-Spring-2025/home/executive_challenges (each an "*Hackathon Challenge*").

5.2 Upload your Submission to an online GitHub repository; and

5.3 Create a page on Innovation Studio for your entry that includes the following information:

(a) The names of your Team Members;
(b) The Executive Challenge you chose to solve for;
(c) A short description of your Team's Solution;
(d) A link to the repository for your Solution;
(e) A video demonstration of your Solution, including a PowerPoint presentation describing your goals, your Solution's components and architecture, how you thought through your approach, and any key learnings; and
(f) The PowerPoint Presentation from your Video Entry.

The entry limit is one (1) per Team overall. Any attempt by your Team to obtain more than the stated number of entries by using multiple/different accounts, identities, registrations, logins, or any other methods will void your Team's entries and your Team may be disqualified. Use of any automated system to participate is prohibited. Teams may only provide individual Team Member's personal data to Microsoft in accordance with Section 13 (Privacy) below.

We are not responsible for excess, lost, late, or incomplete entries. If disputed, entries will be deemed submitted by the "authorized account holder" of the email address, social media account, or other method used to enter. The "authorized account holder" is the natural person assigned to an email address by an internet or online service provider, or other organization responsible for assigning email addresses.

## 6. ELIGIBLE ENTRY

To be eligible, an entry must meet the following content/technical requirements:

- Your entry must be your own original work; **and**
    - *Please note the video portion of your entry must be solely the work of the team, including but not limited to, the actual filming, editing, graphic design, etc. of the video.*
- Your entry cannot have been selected as a winner in any other contest; **and**
- You must have obtained all consents, approvals, or licenses required for you to submit your entry; **and**
- To the extent that entry requires the submission of user-generated content such as software, photos, videos, music, artwork, essays, etc., entrants warrant that their entry is their original work, has not been copied from others without permission or apparent rights, and does not violate the privacy, intellectual property rights, or other rights of any other person or entity. You may include Microsoft trademarks, logos, and designs, for which Microsoft grants you a limited license to use for the sole purposes of submitting an entry into this Contest; **and**
- Your entry may NOT contain, as determined by us in our sole and absolute discretion, any content that is obscene or offensive, violent, defamatory, disparaging or illegal, or that promotes alcohol, illegal drugs, tobacco or a particular political agenda, or that communicates messages that may reflect negatively on the goodwill of Microsoft.
- Contain any computer viruses, malware, spyware, or other malicious or illicit code that will degrade or infect any products, services, or any other software or Microsoft's network or systems.
- The video portion of your entry may not be longer than fifteen (15) minutes in length.

## 7. USE OF YOUR ENTRY

We are not claiming ownership rights to your Submission. However, by submitting an entry, you grant us an irrevocable, royalty-free, worldwide right and license to use, review, assess, test and otherwise analyze your entry and all its content in connection with this Contest and use your entry in any media whatsoever now known or later invented for any non-commercial or commercial purpose, including, but not limited to, the marketing, sale or promotion of Microsoft products or services, without further permission from you. You will not receive any compensation or credit for use of your entry, other than what is described in these Official Rules.

By entering you acknowledge that we may have developed or commissioned materials similar or identical to your entry and you waive any claims resulting from any similarities to your entry. Further you understand that we will not restrict work assignments of representatives who have had access to your entry, and you agree that use of information in our representatives' unaided memories in the development or deployment of our products or services does not create liability for us under this agreement or copyright or trade secret law.

Your entry may be posted on a public website. We are not responsible for any unauthorized use of your entry by visitors to this website. We are not obligated to use your entry for any purpose, even if it has been selected as a winning entry.

## 8. WINNER SELECTION AND NOTIFICATION

Pending confirmation of eligibility, potential prize winners will be selected by Microsoft or their Agent or a qualified judging panel from among all eligible entries received based on the following judging criteria:

- 25% - Solution Performance (i.e Does your Solution work?)

- 25% - Innovation (i.e. Does your Solution enable a new scenario, take a new approach, or overcome obstacles in a creative way?)
- 25% - Adherence to the Microsoft Responsible AI Standard (see here)
- 25% - Breadth of Azure Tools used (i.e. Does you Solution take full advantage of the Azure platform?)

Winners will be selected within seven (7) days following the Entry Period from among all eligible entries received.

In the event of a tie between any eligible entries, an additional judge will break the tie based on the judging criteria described above. The decisions of the judges are final and binding. If we do not receive enough entries meeting the entry requirements, we may, at our discretion, select fewer winners than the number of Contest Prizes described below.

Winners will be notified via the contact information provided during entry no more than seven (7) days following judging with prize claim instructions, including submission deadlines. If the winning Team cannot be contacted, is ineligible, fails to claim a prize or fails to return any Forms, the selected winner will forfeit their prize and an alternate winner will be selected time allowing. If you are a potential winner and you are eighteen (18) or older but have not reached the age of majority in your place of legal residence, we may require your parent/legal guardian to sign all required forms on your behalf. Only three (3) alternate winners will be selected, after which unclaimed prizes will remain unawarded.

**9. PRIZES**

The following prizes will be awarded:

**One (1) First Prize.** The first-place winning Team will receive:
A Cash Prize, to be made as a wire transfer and split evenly among all Team Members. Approximate Retail Value (ARV) $10,000.00 USD.

**Two (2) Second Prizes.** The second-place winning Team will receive:
A Cash Prize, to be made as a wire transfer and split evenly among all Team Members. Approximate Retail Value (ARV) $5,000.00 USD.

**Three (3) Third Prizes.** The third-place winning Team will receive:
A Cash Prize, to be made as a wire transfer and split evenly among all Team Members. Approximate Retail Value (ARV) $2,500.00 USD.

The ARV of electronic prizes is subject to price fluctuations in the consumer marketplace based on, among other things, any gap in time between the date the ARV is estimated for purposes of these Official Rules and the date the prize is awarded or redeemed. We will determine the value of the prize to be the fair market value at the time of prize award.

The total Approximate Retail Value (ARV) of all prizes: **$27,500.00 USD.**

We will only award one (1) prize per Team during the Entry Period. No more than the stated number of prizes will be awarded. No substitution, transfer, or assignment of prize permitted, except that Microsoft reserves the right to substitute a prize of equal or greater value in the event the offered prize is unavailable. Microsoft products awarded as prizes are awarded “AS IS” and WITHOUT WARRANTY OF ANY KIND, express or implied (including any implied warranty of merchantability or fitness for a

particular purpose); you assume the entire risk of quality and performance, and should the prizes prove defective, you assume the entire cost of all necessary servicing or repair. This is so even if the Microsoft product mentions a warranty on its packaging, in a manual, or in marketing materials; no warranty applies to Microsoft products awarded as prizes. Microsoft does not give any warranty of any kind, express or implied (including any implied warranty of merchantability or fitness for a particular purpose) on products made by a company other than Microsoft that are awarded as prizes. Please contact the manufacturer to see if it is covered by that company's warranty.

Prizes will be sent no later than forty-two (42) days after winner selection. Prize winners may be required to complete and return prize claim and/or tax forms ("*Forms*") within the deadline stated in the winner notification. Taxes on the prize, if any, are the sole responsibility of the winner, who is advised to seek independent counsel regarding the tax implications of accepting a prize. By accepting a prize, you agree that Microsoft may use your entry, name, image and hometown online and in print, or in any other media, in connection with this Contest without payment or compensation to you, except where prohibited by law.

**10. ODDS**

The odds of winning are based on the number and quality of eligible entries received.

**11. GENERAL CONDITIONS AND RELEASE OF LIABILITY**

To the extent allowed by law, by entering you agree to release and hold harmless Microsoft and its respective parents, partners, subsidiaries, affiliates, employees, and agents from any and all liability or any injury, loss, or damage of any kind arising in connection with this Contest or any prize won.

All local laws apply. The decisions of Microsoft are final and binding.

We reserve the right to cancel, change, or suspend this Contest for any reason, including cheating, technology failure, catastrophe, war, or any other unforeseen or unexpected event that affects the integrity of this Contest, whether human or mechanical. If the integrity of the Contest cannot be restored, we may select winners from among all eligible entries received before we had to cancel, change or suspend the Contest.

If you attempt or we have strong reason to believe that you have compromised the integrity or the legitimate operation of this Contest by cheating, hacking, creating a bot or other automated program, or by committing fraud in any way, we may seek damages from you to the full extent of the law and you may be banned from participation in future Microsoft promotions.

**12. GOVERNING LAW**

This Contest will be governed by the laws of the State of Washington, and you consent to the exclusive jurisdiction and venue of the courts of the State of Washington for any disputes arising out of this Contest.

**13. PRIVACY**

Teams will not provide any individual Team Member's personal data to Microsoft except as explicitly requested by Microsoft, and then only after notifying Team Members that their personal data will be submitted to Microsoft in connection with the Contest. Teams will not include any individual Team

Member's personal data in the information or submissions they provide to Microsoft in connection with the Contest.

Personal data you provide while entering this Contest will be used by Microsoft and/or its agents and prize fulfillers acting on Microsoft's behalf only for the administration and operation of this Contest and in accordance with the Microsoft Privacy Statement.

**14. WINNERS LIST**

Send an email to macalde@microsoft.com with the subject line "Innovation Challenge Hackathon March 2026 winners" within thirty (30) days of March 27, 2026 to receive a list of winners that received a prize.